
Leveraging Generative Artificial Intelligence with Transparency: Enhancing Academic Integrity in Higher Education

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Generative artificial intelligence (GenAI) tools have brought substantial changes to the education system, in particular to the writing process. Students must learn how to use these tools correctly and with integrity. It is the role of institutions and instructors to convey to students the importance of transparency, and how to display it when using GenAI tools to write assignments. In this paper, a theoretical model of academic assignment writing is presented, explaining at which phases of the writing process GenAI can be used with integrity and which phases must absolutely be done by the student. The appropriate use of GenAI tools when deploying informational, writing and referencing competencies to write an assignment is discussed. Advice on modifying existing institutional academic integrity policies, giving clear guidelines and permissions are presented as well as various methods of declaring GenAI usage.

Keywords: generative artificial intelligence; transparency; academic integrity, higher education; academic writing; assignments

INTRODUCTION

Today's world is constantly evolving, and technology contributes to the rapidity and evolution (Duderstadt, 2008). Recently, in education, artificial intelligence (AI) has brought major shifts in the teaching and learning paradigms, forcing instructors to revise traditional methods of teaching and evaluating (Chen et al., 2020). The introduction of AI tools, whether they are generative AI (GenAI) or simply AI,¹ has opened new ways of enriching the education experience for teachers and students (Perera & Lankathilake, 2023). The coming months and years will see the gradual integration of AI tools into higher education (Abbas et al., 2023).

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One of the biggest changes AI is bringing to education is the support it can offer for improving the quality and efficiency of the process of writing (Alharbi, 2023). Whether the writing is for scientific articles (like this one) for instructors or for student assignments, AI tools help ‘users to diversify the ideas in their writing while keeping it clear and concise more quickly’ (Pereira et al., 2023, p. 1). AI tools can provide quick feedback that the writer can use to improve their text (Hwang et al., 2023). The use of these tools has enormous potential to make the writing process more productive and easier (Noy & Zhang, 2023).

However, instructors and students must learn to use these tools correctly and responsibly. In an academic context, a high percentage of AI-generated text, detected in an assignment submitted for evaluation, will be considered plagiarism with possible consequences for the student² (Qasem, 2023). Instructors must teach, and students must learn how to use AI tools to help with their writing but not to write for them (Friesen & Polziehn, 2024). A text submitted for evaluation will serve to judge a student’s skills and knowledge and award a grade and eventually a diploma. That is why the use of AI tools must, always, be acknowledged in students’ assignments to preserve the validity of diplomas. If students explain how much and how they have used AI, transparency will safeguard integrity and honesty in education.

The goal of this article is to explore how AI tools can be used with integrity during the writing of assignments and the roles institutions and instructors must play to convey to students the importance of transparency and how to display it when using AI tools to write assignments.

LEGITIMATE USE OF AI IN THE PROCESS OF WRITING AN ASSIGNMENT

Certain uses of AI should not be considered an academic infraction at different phases of the writing process: planning, information searching, revising, referencing, and writing phases. Of course, this would vary for each assignment according to the instructions given by the instructor.

Peters (2023c) presents her model of ‘the era of honest writing with AI’ in which she indicates how three different types of competencies are in play in the writing process: informational, writing, and referencing. The author shows which phases of the writing process can use AI (in blue) with integrity and which phases (in gold) must absolutely be done by the

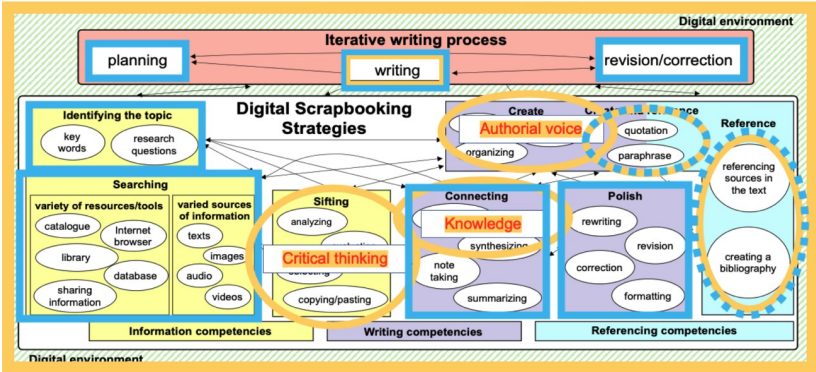


FIGURE 1. The Era of Honest Writing with Artificial Intelligence (Peters, 2023c)

student. The entire process is surrounded by a gold rectangle, indicating that whether AI is used or not, the entire responsibility for the assignment lies with the student (Peters, 2023c). AI cannot be a co-author because it is not a person and so cannot be held responsible for the text (Committee on Publication Ethics Council, 2023a; Nature, 2023).

Legitimate Use of AI for Planning an Assignment

Research has shown that students who have difficulties writing often do not plan or make outlines for their assignments (Sundari & Febriyanti, 2022). With the use of AI tools, specifically text generators (ChatGPT, Notion AI, Bing, Gemini, etc.), students can generate an outline for an assignment quickly and easily, which can, according to Lin (2024), encourage creative thinking. This is no different than brainstorming with a friend and is a perfectly legitimate use of AI. Teachers should teach students how to generate an outline with AI for their assignments, explaining very clearly that the prompts need to ask solely for a list of ideas for the assignment and not for a completed text that could be tempting to copy and paste.

Legitimate Use of AI for Information Searching

Before the arrival of GenAI in colleges and universities, students routinely used web browsers to search for information (Nikolopoulou & Gialamas, 2011). The web is considered a useful source of information by instructors (Filistea et al., 2010) and not as an academic infraction. This should then

also apply to employing AI tools to search for information. Students can use generic tools to search for information such as ChatGPT or Claude, but ideas given by these tools will then need to be further researched to find the original authors and sources given by the students (Juárez & Baumgartner, 2023). Information retrieval with AI tools that specialise in information search such as Consensus, Research Rabbit, or Perplexity can help students find relevant ideas and their sources.

Critical Thinking Skills Need to Be Applied to Information Searches

The accountability and responsibility of the assignment, as mentioned before, lies completely with the students and not with any AI tools used. This signifies that students must verify not once but twice the veracity of the information given by the AI tools (Marbun, 2023). This will prevent including in their assignments AI hallucinations that seem like real facts but are not (Dhuliawala et al., 2023). Students' critical thinking skills are essential in the information search process (Darwin et al., 2023; Marbun, 2023) whether the information is found on Google or with an AI. Students are ultimately the ones that choose the information to include in their assignments and for that, they need to analyse and evaluate the information, select the details that are relevant, and find credible sources to back it up if there is doubt on the veracity of the information. Students must understand the need to justify the information they find and use (Muthmainnah et al., 2022) and why these justifications from credible sources give increased reliability to their assignments (Mikkonen, 2018). This process will not only augment the quality of the assignment (Shao & Purpur, 2016) but also show how students respect academic integrity.

Legitimate Use of AI for Writing Assignments

Once students have found information for their assignments, they must organise their thoughts and connect the information they will use with what they already know. They must also make sure that they properly interpret and understand the information they have gathered. This process can involve note taking, synthesising, or summarising the information. Certain AI tools can be used for these tasks, acting as tutors to help capture the meaning of the information (e.g., see Chat with any PDF, Learn Anything, or PI). This will help students develop the knowledge they need to write papers and will potentially improve the quality of the students' writing and is a perfectly legitimate use of AI tools.

Use Of AI Generating Text in Written Assignments Is Plagiarism

The creative process of organising and integrating the information within the students' writing needs to be done by the students. Yes, AI tools can generate content, whether partial or complete texts, based on prompts crafted by the students. If these texts generated by AI are incorporated verbatim in the students' written product, this will be considered plagiarism.

Peters (2023b), who redefined plagiarism after AI tools appeared in the education system, specifies that any text generated by AI that is passed off as their own by a student, in an evaluation context, will be considered plagiarism. Other authors have gone as far as saying that because the AI tools use texts in their databases that have been written by authors, real human beings, that all text generated by AI is plagiarism because most AI, unless specifically prompted, will not give their sources (Dien, 2023; Dwivedi et al., 2023; Lee et al., 2023). Consequently, students who plagiarise the content generated by an AI tool are plagiarising a plagiarist (Chan, 2023; Yeo, 2023).

Another potential danger is that students who rely excessively on AI tools to help write their assignments will become dependent on these tools and will lose or not develop their own creativity and autonomy when it comes to the writing process. Habib et al. (2024, p. 1) have found that 'while AI has the potential to significantly support creative thinking, there are also negative impacts on creativity.' AI can have negative impacts on creativity. But most importantly, if students do not write their own assignments, they will lose the opportunity to learn.

Legitimate Use of AI Tools to Quote and Paraphrase Authors

When writing an assignment, students will often quote or paraphrase authors to support their arguments (Shi, 2010). Students can augment the quality of their arguments when adding a direct quote or paraphrasing another author's idea showing nuanced rhetorical skills (Lombardi, 2021). This gives credibility to their work and shows engagement with the topic as well as critical analysis of sources (Vardi, 2012).

Students can choose to quote, often doing so when the original text supports particularly well the point they are trying to make (Shi, 2010) or is difficult to paraphrase (Pertwi, 2019). Using AI when quoting is not especially useful because the students can easily copy and paste the sentence or paragraph from the original text.

However, it is different when students need to paraphrase. When paraphrasing, students need to show their understanding of the original sentence by reformulating the original ideas into their own words (Hirvela & Du, 2013). Paraphrasing another author's ideas can maintain the students' writing style since the voice is the same throughout the assignment (Mira & Fatimah, 2020) and using AI tools can facilitate the process of paraphrasing and improve the clarity of the assignment (Perkins, 2023). There are two potential problems when using AI paraphrasing tools such as DeepL Write, QuillBot, or Grammarly.

The first problem is the amount of paraphrasing done with AI. Using AI paraphrasing tools to paraphrase a short passage in an assignment does not constitute plagiarism if it is limited to a handful of sentences and appropriately referenced. However, these tools can be used to reformulate large portions of texts which can then be passed off as the students' work which would be plagiarism. The crux of the issue is 1) whether the paraphrased text is cited as well as 2) the number of sentences paraphrased with AI that are included in the assignment.

The second but more problematic situation when students use AI paraphrasing tools is the potential threat to learning. This is why it is vital that students do not use AI to paraphrase when they do not understand the original text as this will certainly show in the integration of the paraphrase in the assignment. Using AI paraphrasing tools in this case will rob students of the chance to understand the original source.

Legitimate Use of AI for Correcting-Revising an Assignment

When it comes time to correct and revise their assignments, some students will choose to do it during the writing process while others will wait till the end (Myhill & Jones, 2007). AI tools, such as DeepL Write, QuillBot or Grammarly, can not only be used to paraphrase but can also serve as a tool to correct grammatical or punctuation errors or do more complex editing, modifying sentence structure or style of writing, for example.

Using AI in this way can let students concentrate on the content of the assignment knowing the AI will help with the more technical aspects of the writing. For most students, this hybrid writing (Eaton, 2023) should produce better-quality text and should not be considered plagiarism (Perkins, 2023). However, it goes without saying that if the AI tool is used to rewrite the entire assignment to the point where the student's writing is no longer discernable, this will be considered plagiarism because the

student will not have written the assignment, but the AI will. This is especially true in a language class where writing is the skill being assessed.

Students can also use AI tools to get feedback on their writing during or at the end of the writing process. The students will be the ones correcting and revising their assignment according to the comments they will have received from the AI. This is an excellent way to use AI with integrity and as a tutor or learning tool.

Legitimate Use of AI for Referencing an Assignment

Referencing can be challenging for students when they write an assignment (Gravett & Kinchin, 2018). Some students might not know the proper style they need to use (APA [American Psychological Association], MLA [Modern Language Association], Chicago, etc.) with their respective rules for citation in the text or the format in the bibliography (Greer, 2018). Others might have problems accessing all the information needed to give proper references (Kargbo, 2010) especially when it comes to electronic sources (Head et al., 2010) while others might not have the best organisational skills and lose the information necessary to give the references (Greenwood et al., 2014). An AI tool such as Typeset can help students make sure that they adhere to the proper referencing style throughout their assignment. Other AI tools such as EndNote and Mendeley can help students find papers they need for their assignment and then organise and format the references. These tools can be extremely useful because they can simplify and accelerate the referencing process and possibly prevent accidental plagiarism from students who lack referencing knowledge.

However, as useful as these AI tools can be, students must never forget that they must verify that all the referencing information they found is exact and complete. Ultimately, they are responsible for the accuracy of the references since mistakes could lead to allegations of plagiarism. Students should use referencing AI tools for support and not to replace their own comprehension of the sources and their management.

USING AI WITH INTEGRITY WHILE WRITING AN ASSIGNMENT: THE NEED FOR TRANSPARENCY

For certificates and diplomas to be valid, in this new age of AI, institutions and professors must foster academic integrity. A diploma is worth only the paper it is written on if there is no learning, if students' assignments

are done with AI. Both the institutions and the instructors have a role to play in fostering integrity and learning and, most of all, must demand transparency from students when they use AI in their assignments. This means that clear guidelines must be established at the level of the institutions as well as the instructor level, in the course outline.

Modifying Existing Institutional Academic Integrity Policies to Include AI

Before institutions can start thinking about implementing new policies about GenAI, they must modify existing policies about academic integrity. These old policies were typically based on a ‘traditional’ definition of plagiarism where plagiarism is the taking of someone else’s words or ideas and passing them off as one’s own without referencing the original author to gain an advantage. This definition must be modified for the following four reasons:

1. This definition, based on direct copying and pasting of existing texts, cannot consider text that has been generated by AI.
2. In the traditional definition of plagiarism, the original author is a person, which means that the attribution of the source is clear. However, in the case of an AI-generated text, the attribution of authorship is complicated and at this point, there is not a consensus on whether AI can be considered an author.
3. Originality and authenticity of the text generated by AI must also be discussed in a new definition of plagiarism. While an AI-generated text is technically original, the words are new every time, the ideas come from the AI’s database which is built on existing texts from human authors. Therefore, unless the AI gives the sources the text is built on, the generated text is plagiarism.
4. Traditional plagiarism detection software was very efficient at identifying traditional plagiarism by matching excerpts between assignments and other texts. At the time of writing this text, AI-generated texts cannot be detected reliably, often giving false positives or even false negatives. This reality must also be built into academic integrity policies.

Therefore, the traditional definition of plagiarism must be broadened for institutions to be better prepared to manage GenAI not only in the present but also in the future AI tools that are constantly appearing on

the market. Policies need to be updated to stay relevant and efficient in a constantly changing digital world. [Peters \(2023b\)](#) proposes a new definition of plagiarism in the era of AI: presenting the words or ideas of another person, or those generated by an AI, without reference to the source from which the information originates, for the purpose of gaining an advantage in an evaluation context ([Peters, 2023a](#)). In this regard, plagiarism comes from using a text or part of a text generated by an AI tool.

Integrating this definition or a similar one will help institutions maintain academic integrity and stay relevant in a world that deals with an increasing number of AI tools.

Clear Guidelines from Institutions on the Use of AI

Higher education institutions have all been faced with the tsunami that has been GenAI since it arrived in November 2022. They have been criticised for their lack of response or the slow speed at which they have responded ([Concannon et al., 2023](#)). In the coming months, higher education institutions must create a new policy to outline AI use, making very clear to students what is allowed and what is not in terms of AI use in different disciplines and programs. These policies will need to include general principles without being too rigid ([Conseil supérieur de l'éducation et Commission de l'éthique en science et en technologie, 2024](#)) and consider the academic freedom of the instructors.

Basic Principles of Guidelines to Include in an AI Policy

There are two basic principles to include when writing an institutional AI policy to ensure the responsible use of AI by students, instructors, and researchers who all have one thing in common: academic writing. The first is that the policy must serve as a reminder that when AI use is permitted, ethical values must be adhered to, such as authenticity of the work and academic honesty and integrity. The second is that there must be mechanisms in place to control the authenticity of students' work. If there is a transgression of these values, sanctions that will be specified in the policy will be applied. Prevention of plagiarism includes deterrents such as sanctions ([Scanlan, 2006](#)).

Defining AI Usage Permissions in Academia

The most important section for the guidelines will be to determine who, what, when, where, and why AI may be used in Academia. The guidelines

will have to be flexible when it comes to who can use AI for their work. All these decisions will benefit from a reflection on how each program should be run.

Who:

- Guidelines will have to consider that undergraduate and graduate students will have different needs and make clear how each level will be allowed to use AI tools.
- Students from different disciplines will also benefit from a differentiated approach to AI usage.

What:

- Institutional guidelines need to be explicit that all AI use must be declared as well as tools to detect AI used by instructors.
- Policies will also have to be clear on which AI tools can be used. GenAI tools and translation tools might not be allowed in language courses where the students will be evaluated on their language skills. In disciplinary courses, for example in Architecture, students could use GenAI to help write a report, but the assessment would be on the students' designs.
- The type of AI use would also have to be specified: from help with writing to total text generation or graphics generation, translation of texts, etc.
- However, it is vital that the policy states that no matter what tool is used, the student is the sole person responsible for the errors, the violations of copyrights or the plagiarism that AI tools would have included in the assignment ([Conseil supérieur de l'éducation et Commission de l'éthique en science et en technologie, 2024](#)).

When:

- Institutional guidelines might include banning the use of AI for exams while permitting it for assignments.
- Another possibility would be flexible use according to advancement in a program. For example, students in their first year of a programme might not be allowed to use AI while students in their last year of the programme, when they will have mastered skills from the beginning of the program, would be allowed to use AI for certain tasks.
- Institutions should also allow their instructors to determine in their own courses when students can or cannot use AI.

Where:

- Determine where the use of AI tools is permitted or not should be included in institutional guidelines.
- The use of AI tools could be limited to off-campus assignments which would mean that the in-class work would be done without AI. This could benefit certain teachers who wish to assess students' work without any AI tools.

Why:

- Introducing the benefits and drawbacks of AI use would be a good way to start an AI policy. It should be clearly stated that AI should be used for the benefit of students' experiences, the development of human skills, and critical engagement with AI tools should be promoted. Reasons such as enhanced learning, improved decision-making, innovation, and overall quality improvement could be included in AI guidelines.

Setting up an AI institutional policy is crucial to ensure that students understand how they can or cannot use AI during their studies. However, just as important will be for institutions to train instructors to integrate AI in their teaching as well as train students on responsible use of AI ([Conseil supérieur de l'éducation et Commission de l'éthique en science et en technologie, 2024](#)) and AI literacy ([Kandlhofer et al., 2016](#); [Ng et al., 2021](#)). This includes instructing students on being transparent when using AI in their assignments.

Being Transparent Means Declaring the Use of AI, Not Citing AI

Since GenAI appeared, there has been a debate as to whether it should be cited. Institutional guidelines about AI need to be very clear about the need to cite or not the input of AI in an assignment. This all hinges on whether AI is treated as an author or not.

In 2023, the American Psychological Association (APA) determined that AI would be treated as any author for both in-text citations and in the reference list. This would mean that the author of the algorithm would be cited, for example, OpenAI (2024), every time ChatGPT would be used.

However, the Committee on Publication Ethics ([Committee on Publication Ethics Council, 2023b](#), para. 1) clearly states that 'AI tools cannot meet the requirements for authorship as they cannot take responsibility

for the submitted work.’ ‘AI bots should not be permitted as authors since they have no legal standing and so cannot hold copyright, be sued, or sign off on a piece of research as original’ ([Committee on Publication Ethics Council, 2023a](#), para. 4).

Institutions must determine which position they will adopt. Three concerns need to be considered. First, it must be remembered that AI produces no original content. All generated text is based on information stored in the AI’s database and has been written by an actual human being. At this point, AI tools are still having problems attributing proper sources to the authors whose ideas they are using in their generated text.

The second concern is that the content generated by AI is non-retrievable because every AI response is different, not static. This means that others cannot verify the content like they would for a published article or book. Finally, the responses from any AI tool will vary based on the prompts it receives and how these will be interpreted by the AI. This can lead to fabrications or inconsistencies in the output making it unreliable to be cited.

[Peters \(2024\)](#) proposes that instead of citing AI as a ‘human’ author, it could be included in an ‘AIgraphy’ which would follow the bibliography. The AIgraphy would contain the references to AI, conferring the importance of being transparent in the use of the AI tools yet not giving the credit of the original ideas to the AI but rather to the authors who would be in the bibliography.

Transparent Use of AI Tools

Although there is a debate on whether to cite AI as an author or not, the entire academic community agrees that AI use must be declared. This is why one section of the institutional policy should address the compulsory declaration of AI use by students. One of the values of academic integrity is honesty and declaring the methods used to complete assignments should be required of students. This should be non-negotiable to ensure the fairness of the evaluation by the instructors. Fair grading, the proper assessment of skill development, and pedagogical adjustments all need to be based on the declaration of AI use by students.

Three authors have come up with different ways to be transparent in the use of AI that can be used in students’ assignments or in any type of production. They are presented from the most complete to the shortest report.



FIGURE 2. Three-Dimensional Model by Wahle et al. (2023)

The first, called AI Usage Cards, is by Wahle et al. (2023), a free template by the University of Göttingen. The template is ‘built on their three-dimensional model that takes into account the transparency, integrity, and accountability of generated content’ (see Figure 2).

This template can be used by either students or researchers, although it is clearly oriented towards declaring the use of AI in a research project. The tool produces a report from a series of questions the user must answer about the type of AI used, at which step of the project (ideation, literature review, methodology, experiments, writing, presentation, coding, data, or ethics) and how the AI was used. The report is as detailed or as succinct as the user wants.

Solomon (2023) also produced a completely different way of being transparent when using AI in what he calls an AI Disclosure (see Figure 3). On a scale showing from completely human to completely generated by computer, students would have to show how they used AI for ideation, outlining, writing, and editing their text.

Students can be very explicit by moving the ruler left or right on the scales to show how much help they go from AI, and they could also indicate which tools and prompts that were used to generate content. Unfortunately, this template is not available for use by everyone, which means that students would have to create their own scales.

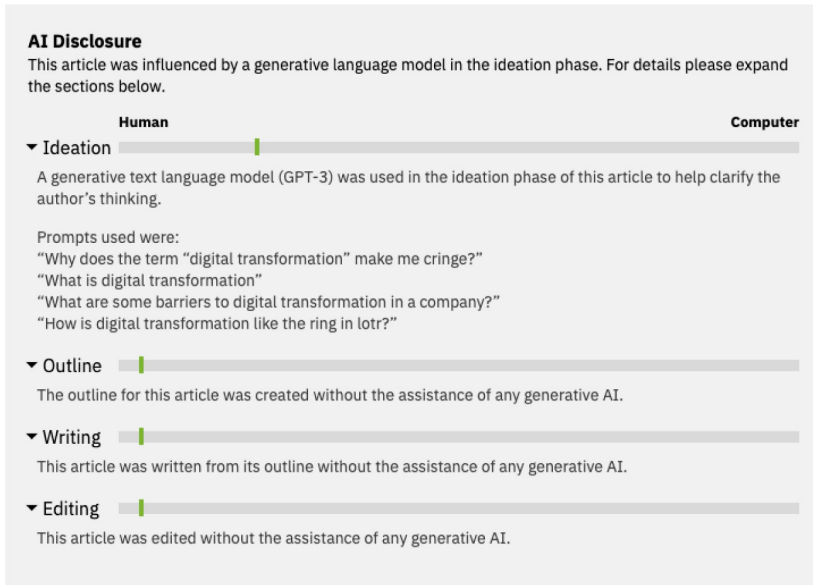


FIGURE 3. AI Disclosure by Solomon (2023)



FIGURE 4. Logos to Show Transparent Use of Artificial Intelligence Tools (Peters, 2023a)

Note: NAI = created without the use of artificial intelligence; AIG = created with the aid of artificial intelligence; AIA = completely generated by artificial intelligence

The simplest way to be transparent about the use of AI was created by Peters (2023a), who designed three logos (see Figure 4). The logos, pictograms depicting a brain, a machine, and a brain with a machine, show that the assignment has been created without the use of AI, with the aid of AI, or has been completely generated by AI.

These logos can be inserted in the footer of an assignment, even changed according to the sections of an assignment if they are done with different levels of help from AI tools.

CONCLUSION

The mission of higher education is to educate students and prepare them for the world they will work in their chosen discipline. Developing skills in students has been mainly the responsibility of instructors, but now, new AI tools have been introduced that have the potential to help students. However, students must beware of not becoming dependent on these tools and must always show that their assignments are the result of their own learning, their critical thinking skills, and their efforts. In turn, this will show their comprehension and mastery of the topics they are studying. Students must declare the use of AI tools so that the instructors can take that use into account when grading assignments.

This transparency is essential to ensure that academic integrity is at the heart of higher education, no matter how many AI tools appear in classrooms. This is why universities must develop clear AI guidelines and policies and promote the responsible use of AI tools that offer students considerable help with academic writing and the learning process in general. Students must be trained in ethical AI use and learn to establish a balance between using AI and fostering their own human skills to learn. This will create an environment where the ethical and transparent use of AI is the norm and not the exception.

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NOTES

1. For this article, generative AI tools will be included in the same general category as AI tools.
2. Other types of AI use can also violate academic integrity, for example, in cheating, but this article is concerned with combatting plagiarism.

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